

Module 1

Cultural factors to understand cross cultural communication skills

“Culture is that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, customs and other capabilities and habits acquired by a man as a member of society” – Sir E.B. Tylor

Most organizations today have people from many different backgrounds and cultures who work together. For organizations the interaction is often beneficial, as diversity fosters ideas and new approaches to new undertakings, decision-making and problem solving. Trying to understand and have good, effective communication between people from different cultural backgrounds is even more challenging, as cultural barriers play an important role as an invisible barrier. People misunderstand each other for a wide variety of reasons, and these misunderstandings can occur between people who are culturally similar as well as those who are different. Ineffective communication of key objectives results in confusion, anxiety, lack of teamwork and low morale. Obstacles in communication arise from lack of knowledge; underlying distrust and apprehension that is a common thing among people from different cultures and these can further escalate into larger problems negatively affecting the production and organizational cohesion.

Edward Hall has advocated three cultural factors for understanding cross cultural communication skills. These factors are categorized as languages of context, time, and space. Set.

Language of Context

Hall and Hall (1990) classified language of context as a high- context language and low context language. A high- context language communicates very little in explicit message and relies more on nonverbal cues and cultural aspects. In a high- context language, people must read between the lines to understand the intended meaning of the message. A high- context language, does involve several unwritten and non-specific rules and it often leads to misunderstanding. Examples of a high - context language and culture are Japanese, Chinese, and many Arabian cultures. On the other- hand, a low- context, language and culture employs explicit quotes or the spoken word. In low- context language people precisely say what they mean. High- context languages tend to be indirect and nonverbal, while low - context languages are direct and verbal. Examples of low - context language and cultures include United States, Swiss, and Scandinavian cultures.

Language of Time

Time is the second cultural factor, which in nonverbal connotation is referred to as either monochronic or polychronic. In Monochronic time cultures, linear language is used. In other words, things are done in an object- oriented and logical manner with a beginning, middle and an end. In the USA and the English cultures, time is perceived on a continuum of present, past and future. For instance, in the US, time is money and hence it is supreme and should not be wasted on unproductive and irrelevant matters. Polychronic cultures, on the other hand, are circular, tradition oriented and subjective. In Polychronic cultures, people place more importance on personal involvement than stipulated deadlines. Latin Americans, who follow polychronic time cultures, prefer to spend some time in socializing before the beginning of the business meeting.

Language of Space

The third cultural factor is the language of space in nonverbal communication, It is defined as the study of how to use space in communication and is known as proxemics. An American may find as being crowded, while an Arab might regard the experience spacious. North Americans generally maintain a space of two or four feet while communicating. Latin Americans and Arabs prefer less than two feet distance during conversations.

Strategies for Adapting to various Cultures

Diversity can bring about distinct advantage in the workplace and in their world. Though it may appear challenging, it is at the same time rich and profitable. With the advancement in technology, distance has become an outdated concept and diversity is bound to settle in every field and business. In such a situation, it is best to embrace diversity and make employees aware of how to thrive in diverse culture.

Several strategies have been advocated to capitalize on diversity for the growth of the organizations and institutions or in workforce. Some of them are discussed as under:

1. **Study and understand different cultures:** Studying different cultures include studying a country's history, economics, geography, politics, religion and psychology. Understanding business practices, laws and customs of other countries is paramount to function in a diverse work environment. Awareness of different cultures can be created through training, observation and interaction. Studying role behaviors of different cultures help to understand communication and decision making. For example, in masculine cultures men need to be assertive, successful and ambitious, while women may or may not be so.
2. **Know and understand language of context:** Cultural communications can be understood if a person knows the difference between high context and low context of language and culture. Since high context cultures use more of implicit messages, it becomes challenging for a person of low context culture to read between the lines and vice versa. Hence, awareness and in depth understanding of these differences will save global citizens from the perils of misunderstanding and misinterpretation.
3. **Know and respect language of time:** It is important to know and respect how both monochronic and polychronic time cultures function. For example, South Americans from polychronic time culture are habitually late for meetings and they like to spend some time in socializing before they get to work. Hence, to judge them negatively for not respecting time may lead to misinterpretations.
4. **Know and acknowledge language of space:** A proper understanding of how space is used in communication in different parts of the world can eliminate hostility and negativity of cross-cultural / intercultural communication. Hence, due consideration should be given to the language of space in all the businesses.
5. **Be sensitive to others:** If you accidentally offend somebody, apologize immediately. This will reduce the ill- feeling at once. By being sensitive, one can develop goodwill and credibility in others. Impromptu casual interactions among team players are some of the ways of understanding human emotions, which are also a significant aspect of culture.
6. **Be an empathetic listener/ empathy:** We must listen twice as much as we talk as we possess two years and one mouth. Most of the problems related to communication arise as there is little

emphasis on listening and more on speaking. Listening as a skill is the most sought after requirement for a managerial position. As far as the role of managers goes, empathy is highly demanded which goes hand in hand with listening. Hence active or empathetic listening skills should be developed by managers for understanding the point of view of other people. As we move towards higher levels in hierarchy in an organization, we find that listening coupled with empathy become extremely important. As a leader, one needs to spend more time in listening to customers, subordinates and other stakeholders. But this listening will be fruitful if it is complemented by empathy.

- a) Listening patiently with empathy to develop the factor of trust in the speaker.
 - b) Concentrate on understanding the speaker.
 - c) Use verbal and nonverbal cues to show that you understand the speaker's point of view.
 - d) Signals such as head nod, eye contact, and suitable sounds are needed to show that your full attention is on the speaker.
 - e) Reinforce the message by paraphrasing it.
 - f) Seek the clarification if you are not able to understand any point in the message.
 - g) Always suspend your judgments during the whole process and listen with open mind devoid of biases or prejudices. In short, do not judge people, but listen to understand them.
7. **Adopt proper cultural perspective:** People from low context cultures rush to work and get down to business first because they value expertise and performance more than personal rapport. On the other hand, people from high context cultures spend more time in socializing and rituals, hence they are slow in negotiations and decision making. Hence it is necessary to have a proper perspective of different cultures.
8. **Appreciate and respect cultural differences:** Be open minded and positive towards others cultures. This attitude will aid in strengthening the channels of cross-cultural communication. As managers and leaders, be an empathetic listener, spend time with team members, organize social events and sponsor cultural awareness events. This will create a very positive environment and people will be respectful and appreciative of diverse cultural practices.
9. **Educate yourself through training opportunities:** Nowadays we see that several organizations provide onsite training on cross cultural or intercultural issues to their employees. The very fact that these training programs are organized to inculcate good understanding of diversity is a testimony to their efforts of building relationships and of acknowledging people of different cultures. Trainings and educational programs in this area help in fostering the values of trust and mutual respect for each other.

Culture and communication

People learn patterns of behavior from their culture. *“Culture makes people understand each other better, and if they understand each other better in their soul, it is easier to overcome the economic and political barriers. But they have to understand that their neighbor is, in the end, just like them, with the same problem, the same questions”* – Paulo Coelho. The culture of a people is the product of their living experiences within their own society. Culture could be described as “the way of life” of a people and includes a vast array of behaviors and beliefs. These patterns affect how people perceive the world, what they value, and how they act. Differing patterns can also create barriers to communication.

Culture can be observed at three levels, and understanding each level helps in modifying our communication style to suit the needs that arise due to cultural diversity.

- **Visible level** – This is the level of culture we first encountered when we go to a new place. This includes all physical and visible elements of culture, such as dress, art, music, monuments, food, and artifacts. The visible level shows us what is different in a region, but does not inform about how to deal with such differences. At best, it guides us to make adaptations at the superficial level with respect to dress codes, public conduct, among others, so that we can blend and not stand out too much in a new place. To understand culture at a deeper level, we need to examine the behavioral level, of a culture.
- **Behavioral level** – This level explains how members of a cultural group communicate, explain, rationalize, and behave in different situations. When we observe culture at this level, we know how differences in age, gender, class, and status impact communication style in a particular culture, and we may learn how to deal appropriately with negative, positive, and neutral messages. For example, when attending funerals in India, you are expected to be more sympathetic and even vocal unlike in Western settings, where grief is considered to be a private matter and visitors must be discreet in expressing sympathy. However, at the behavioral level, we are still unaware of the underlying reasons for the differences we see, for which we need to get to the third and the deepest and least visible aspect of a culture: the basic assumptions about life or belief systems shared by members of a cultural group.
- **Belief System**- this system answers fundamental questions about life, such as where have we come from or where will we go after death, what is the purpose and meaning of human existence, morality, and so on. Beliefs are drawn from long – standing philosophic- spiritual or politico- social traditions prevailing in a cultural group. These traditions have an adaptive function and endure because one generation passes. Get to the next through the process of socialization. Belief systems shape, attitudes, values, goals, and means shared by cultural groups. Understanding belief system helps in formulating suitable business negotiation strategies, resolving conflicts, and using appropriate verbal and nonverbal symbols. While communicating.

Dimensions of cultural differences in workforce

- **Power Distance**- power distance describes the extent to which less powerful people expect and accept the fact that power is unequal within the country or an organization. In many

cultures we see power gap or power distance, which means positional respect. Hofstede found that people in Malaysia, Panama, the Philippines, India and Mexico were most accepting of power distance, while Austrians, Israelis, Danes, New Zealanders, and the Irish were the least accepting of power distance.

- **Individualism versus collectivism** – Individualistic cultures are those that emphasize individual goals and behaviors, while collectivist cultures emphasize group goals and behaviors. In individualist cultures, people are supposed to look out for themselves and their family only, while in collectivist cultures, people belong to groups and collectivities that are supposed to look after them in exchange for their loyalty.
- **Masculinity versus femininity**- Cultures that are high in masculinity enforce distinctly different roles for men and women, while those that are more feminine allow for the blurring of roles between men and women. Middle Eastern cultures, including India are generally high in masculinity, while the Scandinavian countries allow men and women to share roles and personal characteristics and behaviors.
- **Uncertainty avoidance**- in some cultures, people are more comfortable accepting risk. In the United States, for example, it does not seem unusual for people to leave their jobs to start businesses, even though the odds of failure are high. In contrast, people in some countries, such as France, prefer jobs with a lifetime guarantee of employment.

Barriers to intercultural / cross-cultural communication

The cross-cultural communication or intercultural communication is a vast area and needs due consideration to ensure the success of an organization and its employees. Because cultures give different definitions to such basics of interaction as values and norms, people raised in two different cultures may clash in various ways. Barriers to intercultural communication include ethnocentrism, stereotypes, chronemics, proxemics, haptics, kinesics and language.

- **Ethnocentrism**- problems occur between people of different cultures primarily because people tend to assume that their own cultural norms are the right way to do things. It also occurs when one perceives one's culture as the central culture and believes that other cultures are defective or quaint. In other words, a belief that one's own cultural values, beliefs, language, verbal and nonverbal signals are correct and better than those of the other people, is known as ethnocentrism. It often leads to misunderstanding and misinterpretation. This belief is certainly natural; but learning about other cultures and developing sensitivity will help minimize ethnocentric reactions when dealing with other cultures.
- **Stereotypes**- we often form a mental picture of the main characteristics of another group, creating pre-formed ideas of what people in this group are like. These pictures, called stereotypes, influence the way we interact with members of the other group when we observe a behavior that conforms to the stereotype, the validity of the preconceived notion is reinforced. We often view the other person as a representative of a class of people rather than as an individual. People of all cultures have stereotypes about other cultural groups they have encountered. These stereotypes can interfere with communication when people interact on the basis of the imagined representative and not the real individual. In India, we have stereotypes based on regional and caste differences, role - relationships that act as barriers to communication.

- **Interpretation of time-** The study of how a culture perceives time and its use is called natural space requirements is known as proxemics. In India, time is perceived to be limitless. It is common to arrive at social occasions much later than the time mentioned on the invitation. However, in private sector companies, practically everyone is punctual, although there is tardiness in government organizations, but this is also fast changing. The private sector managers are accustomed to working late beyond the official timings, unlike western countries, where people generally do not allow work time to encroach on leisure time. In the United States, there is a saying that “time is money”. Canadians like, like some northern Europeans who are also concerned about punctuality, make appointments, keep them, and do not waste time completing them. In some cultures, long casual conversations prior to serious discussions or negotiations are time well spent in establishing and nurturing relationships.
- **Personal space requirements** – Space operates as a language, just as time does. The study of cultural space requirements is known as **proxemics**. In all cultures, the distance between people functions in communication as “personal space” or “personal territory”. In India, gender dictates the distance to be maintained between two individuals. For example, members of the same gender can stand close to each other, but those of opposite genders must remain at a distance. However, in many cultures outside the United States, closer personal contact is accepted, or greater distance may be the norm. Generally speaking, United States tend to need more space than those from Greece, Latin America, or the Middle East, while the Japanese prefer a greater distance than people of the United States in social situations.
- **Touching-** Touch, or **haptics**, communicates a great deal what is appropriate, and people’s tendency to touch differs by culture and gender. Sydney Jourard conducted a study in which he found that adults in Puerto Rico touched 180 times per hour; those in Paris touched about 110 times per hour. In India, two men holding hands or having their arms slung around each other’s shoulder is not an uncommon sight. This is not the case in the western world, where a male touching another is seen as a display of sexual preference. Age and gender are important in India, and men will not usually touch women and vice versa. In government organizations, greeting a woman colleague may not involve a handshake, but is a folded hand gesture called “*Namaste*”, though men greet each other with a handshake. In a social setting, it is customary to bow down and touch the feet of elders while greeting. However, the handshake is fast becoming the preferred style of greeting among Indians.
- **Body language** – The study of body language is known as **kinesics**. The body language is not universal, but instead is learned from one’s culture. Even the most basic gestures have varying cultural meanings- the familiar North American symbol for “okay” means zero in France, money in Japan, an expression of vulgarity in Brazil, and “excellent” in India. Similarly, eye contact, posture, and facial expressions carry different meanings throughout the world. In China, for example, people rarely express emotions, while Japanese may smile to show a variety of emotions, such as happiness, sadness, or even anger. In India, people do not mind being stared at, while in Western countries, it is considered rude. The right hand is considered auspicious and left hand unclean. When giving and taking money, eating food, or presenting gifts, the right hand is always used. Sitting with the foot pointing at another person (as also in many Southeast Asian countries) is considered rude and offensive. People adopt a differential style when dealing with hierarchy, often giving them the “right of way” in many situations.

- **Translation limitation** – words in one language do not always have an equivalent meaning in other languages, and the concepts the words describe are often different as well. Translators can be helpful, but keep in mind that a translator is working with a second language and must listen to one language, mentally cast the words into another language, and then speak them. This process is difficult and opens the possibility that the translator will fall victim to one or more cultural barriers.
Instead of ignoring cultural factors, employees and employers can improve communication by recognizing them, working to understand them better, and considering people as individuals rather than as members of stereotypical groups.
- **Common sense approach** – minimize the barriers to intercultural communication by applying a few commonsense guidelines:
 - Learn about and experience other cultures.
 - Cultivate patience with yourself and with others.
 - Get help when you need it.
- **Learn about and experience other cultures-** Many sources of information are available, including books, Internet sites and workshops. But more fun avenues for learning about other culture exist, such as meeting people from other cultures, getting to know them and their culture, and traveling to other countries and spending time in local communities.

Key terms which are often used in the context of cross-cultural processes or cultural diversity in workplace:

- Intracultural communication** is one when communication occurs among members of the same culture. A Japanese talking to another Japanese is an example of intracultural communication or an Indian talking to another Indian is also an example of intercultural communication.
- Intercultural communication** as defined, involves communication among people of different cultures. An Indian meeting a Chinese businessman over a business lunch is an example of intercultural communication.
- Enculturation** is a process of socialization wherein people adapt to the culture of their own society. For example, an American mother teaching her child to eat with a fork and knife. Or a child learning a good habit of not stealing anything from anyone in school is enculturation.
- Acculturation** is defined as the process of adapting and adjusting to a new and different culture. For instance, a Hispanic or South American who moves to the United States would have to learn English in order to fully understand and communicate in the American culture.
- Ethnocentrism** occurs when one perceives one's culture as the central culture and believes that other cultures are defective or quaint. In other words, a belief that one's own cultural values, beliefs, language, verbal and nonverbal signals are correct and better than those of the other people is known as ethnocentrism. The best example. Of ethnocentrism is that of 16th century European imperialism.
- Cultural intelligence** includes those skills and set of abilities which are culturally In Sync with the values, beliefs, and attitudes of other people. For instance, if you are aware of Spanish culture, you would know that meeting someone ten minutes after your appointed time is not considered late. Hence if your Spanish colleague turns up late for the meeting, you need to adapt yourself to this new cultural context, only then you would be considered as culturally intelligent.

- g) **Polycentrism** involves those management practices which consider the culture of the country where the firm is located. Management considers the cultural needs of the workers in the area in which the firm is situated. Companies use polycentric approach while hiring employees. Host countries' nationals are aware of the customs, laws and cultures of their own country. Having large number of employees from host countries ensures smooth business transactions.
- h) **Regiocentrism** gives more emphasis on the region than to the country in which the firm is located. This may include a vast region covering more than one country, or a region within a large country. This is because of the fact that countries can, and often do, have many different cultural backgrounds. Regions are grouped on the basis of economic, cultural and political characteristics, and a common framework is developed to include the cultural practices of that region. Coca-Cola, for instance has widely used region centric approach in its marketing strategy. Countries like India, Pakistan and Bangladesh are grouped under one region owing to their similarities and a common marketing strategy has been adopted across these countries.
- i) **Geocentrism** involves a synergy of ideas from different countries of operation. Here a common framework with enough freedom to operate locally is evolved to meet the cultural requirement of different countries of operation. Normally corporations have common control practices, but with enough scope of modifications at the local level. Indian employees working in American MNCs are sent to the USA to get trained in the American way of working. They are at the same time asked to retain cultural context of India.